Squids will be Squids

By Jon Scieszka

Fables have been around for thousands of years. And it's no wonder, because even thousands of years ago people were bright enough to figure out that you could gossip about anybody as long as you changed their name to something like "Lion" "Mouse" or "Donkey" Aesop is the guy most famous for telling fables. Though he wasn't the first or the best looking. Most descriptions of Aesop call him, funny shaped or ugly or worse. But you didn't hear that from me. I think Aesop was one heck of a swell guy.

INTRODUCTION

John Scieszka's book Squids will be Squids. is a collection of fables that Aesop might have told if he were alive today, sitting in the back of the class day dreaming, goofing around instead of paying attention, because his dog ate his homework and he didn't have time to run out and buy new paper and do it over again before his bus came to pick him up in the morning.. Enjoy a few of these contemporary fables today and listen for the Moral of each story and remember . . . Sometimes the names are changed to protect the not so innocent. Squids will be Squids by John Scieszka

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Deer, Mouse, Rabbit and Squid:

Deer, Mouse, Rabbit and Squid sat on the steps trying to decide what to do.

"Let's go see a movie," said Deer.

"Great," said Mouse. "Great" said Rabbit.

"There's nothing good on," said Squid.

"Let's play Frisbee in the park," said Mouse.

"Great," said Rabbit. "Great," said Deer.

"My tentacles are too tired," said Squid.

"Let's go shopping," said Rabbit.

"Great," said Deer. "Great," said Mouse.

"That's so boring," said Squid. "I'm just going to go home," and she oozed off down the street.

"Great," they said. Then they ran off to see a movie, play Frisbee in the park, and go shopping.

MORAL: Squids will be Squids.

Grasshopper Logic:

One bright and sunny day, Grasshopper came

home from school, dropped his backpack and was just about to run outside to meet his friends.

"Where are you going?" his Mom asked.

"Out to meet some friends," said Grasshopper

"Do you have any homework due tomorrow?" asked his Mom.

"Just one small thing for History. I did the rest in class."

"Okay, " said Mom Grasshopper, "Be back at six for dinner.

Grasshopper hung out with his friends, came home promptly at six, ate his dinner, then took out his History homework.

His Mom read the assignment and freaked out.

"Rewrite twelve Greek myths as Broadway musicals. Write music for songs. Design and build all sets. Sew original costumes for each production."

"How long have you known about this assignment?" asked Mom Grasshoper, trying not to scream.

"I don't know," said Grasshopper.

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MORAL: There are plenty of things to say to calm a hopping mad Grasshopper Mmom. "I don't know" is not one of them.

Pigeon Pie:

Pigeon was a very good artist. But she had one very annoying habit.

Every time she finished a painting she would show it and say, "It's not very good" just to get someone to say, "Oh no Pigeon. That's very good."

One day after she chased everyone else away with her annoying habit, she showed her painting to Saber-Toothed Tiger.

"Oh, Look at my painting…. It's not very good."

Saber-Toothed Tiger licked his long saber teeth. "Oh, no, Pigeon. That's very good. I'm sure it will be perfect roasted, fried, or baked in a pie."

Pigeon was puzzled. She had painted a sad-eyed clown. Then she noticed that Saber-Toothed Tiger wasn't looking at the painting. But it was too late and the end of this fable is too messy to even tell.

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MORAL: Whatever looks like a pigeon and acts like a pigeon usually makes good pigeon pie.

Little Walrus:

Little Walrus's mom told her to always tell the truth. One day the phone rang.

Little Walrus was the only walrus home so she answered it: "Hello?"

"Hello, Little Walrus" said Whale, "Is your mom home?"

No, She's out having the hair taken off her lip.

MORAL: You should always tell the truth. But if your mom is out having the hair taken off her lip you might want to forget a few of the details.

Straw and Matches:

It was the end of summer vacation. Straw had done everything he could think of. He was bored. So he

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went over to play with someone he had been warned to stay away from.

"Let's play checkers," said Straw.

"Okay, I'm the red ones. I get to move first. I get two moves and you get one," said Matches

"Forget it," said Straw. "Let's play ping-pong instead."

"Okay. I get the good paddle. You stand on that side. I get to serve first, and you have to close one eye," said Matches.

"Never mind," said Straw. "Maybe we should just watch TV."

"Okay. You sit over there on the floor. I'll sit on the couch. I get the remote and we have to watch my favorite video," said Matches.

"I think I hear my mom calling," said Straw. "I'd better go."

MORAL: Don't play with Matches

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Elephant and Flea:

As Elephant grew older, he also grew more responsible. One day he and Flea went to see a movie. They liked it so much that they saw it again and completely lost track of time. "Oh no" said Elephant, when he checked his watch. "I was supposed to be home ten minutes ago. Rhinoceros is going to be furious. Do you have a quarter so I can call?"

Flea checked his pockets. "Nope. Spent all my money on popcorn."

So Elephant didn't call.

When Elephant finally showed up, at Rhinoceros's house, he was twenty minutes late, and she was furious.

"You could have at least called," said Rhinoceros

MORAL: Elephants never forget, except sometimes.

Piece of Toast and Fruit Loops:

Piece of toast and Fruit Loops sat on the breakfast table arguing over who was loved the most.

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"Of course everyone loves toast the most. I'm half of eggs and toast. I'm all the toast in French toast. I am the toast with the most. Who could not love me?"

Fruit loops said, "I'm a good source of 11 essential vitamins and mineral containing 20% of the minimum daily requirements of vitamin C, Iron, Thiamin, riboflavin, Niacin, Vitamin B6, folate, vitamin B 12 and Zinc, based on a 2,000 calorie a day diet and a 1 cup serving size not including milk. I also have 1 gram of dietary fiber per serving and 12 grams of sugar, yellow dye #6, blue #1 and #2 and red #40. BHT has been added to preserve freshness."

But while Fruit Loops was rattling off his nutrition facts…

Mom had a cup of tea…

"Toast… Toast… toast…." (getting cold)

Dad drank coffee…..

"Fruit loops…. Fruit loops…. Fruit loops…" (getting soggy)

Son ate a doughnut

"Toast…toast…toast" (getting colder)

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Daughter said she'd get a bagel on the way to school.

"Fruit loops…fruit loops… fruit loops…" (getting soggier)

MORAL: Breakfast is the most important meal of the day

Hand, Foot and Tongue:

One evening at dinner, Hand, Foot and Tongue got into a heated argument over who had the toughest job.

"I have the toughest job," said Hand. "Every day I work from sunup to sundown. I button shirts. I tie shoes. I hold the spoon and fork to feed all of us. I have to be strong enough to punch with a fist, and gentle enough to pat a baby. I definitely have the toughest job."

"No you don't," said Foot. "I have the toughest job. Every day I have to carry all of you. And I'm not complaining or anything, but I usually have to do it in the

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dark – stuck in a smelly sock and laced in a shoe. I have the toughest job."

Then Tongue spoke up. "I am a fleshy muscular organ attached to the floor of the mouth. I help in both speech and taste. I start the process of digestion by moving food into position to get ripped and mashed and crushed and smashed to little bits by the teeth. Then I cover the little food bits with saliva and shape them into slimy blobs of guck that I push down the throat and . . . . "

"That's sick," said Hand.

"Disgusting," said Foot.

MORAL: There are some things we don't talk about at the dinner table.

What fun! I should write some of those myself, you are probably thinking . . . But before you get started, it just occurred to me that you might want to know one more little bit about Aesop.

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Aesop used to tell this one fable about a real bossy jerk "Lion" who ruled a city. When the real bossy jerk guy who ruled Aesop's city heard his fable, he didn't like it. So he had Aesop thrown off a cliff.

MORAL: If you are planning to write fables, don't forget to change the people into animals and avoid places with high cliffs.

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier

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